

INTENTIONALITY OF EVERYDAY WORLDS

By Levi O'Connor

THEME

This project examines how human intention becomes embedded in an environment. The material world acts as a physical record of past and present human decisions, motivated by our desires and notions of 'good'. By analyzing these everyday settings, we can see how collective values and social norms are not abstract ideas but are concretely built into or afforded by our surroundings. The focus of this project is on the trace of human agency that remains visible long after the people themselves have passed or are simply not present in frame.

CONSTRUCTED PATHS

The sidewalk in this photograph represents a sociocultural structure that was designed from the belief it creates the most convenient path or greatest pedestrian flow along a designed route.

Yet, the image captures a moment in time where people have carved a more efficient path into the landscape.

This newly formed path is *directive*, in that it exerts a causal force that guides future walkers along the path. It is also *directed*, in that it reflects the desire for a shorter path by those who walk it, which ensures its own (re)production. This cycle of directive force and directed purpose ensures the path's own persistence through repeated use, until collective practice shifts again.



CONTINUED CARE

The fresh flowers placed upon a grave are a powerful inscription of cultural intentionality. They are *directive*, exerting a social and emotional force that guides the living toward a specific stance of reverence and affirms a practice of remembrance. Simultaneously, they are *directed*, manifesting the mourners' personal desire to sustain a social bond with the deceased.

Based on some short literature review, this practice may be a way to regulate death anxiety, which includes the fear of death for oneself and others (Gire, 2014). This practice that maintains a connection with the dead, may transform death anxiety into a managed, relational process, potentially reducing existential dread through continued social bonds. Conceptions of death across cultures has been researched, but it appears to be a problematic field.



INVASIVE PLANTS

English ivy, seen here cloaking a tree and lawn in green leaves, presents itself as a natural occurrence. However, this scene shows an ecology that would not exist without human intervention.

English ivy is an invasive plant species brought by colonists to the Americas in the 1700s. Its presence is the direct result of a cultural preference for a certain aesthetic (due to being evergreen) or a utilitarian need for ground cover, which was prioritized over the long-term health of the native ecosystem.

What appears as a just natural plant growing in this yard is actually a physical inscription of a human value judgment made in the past, whose consequences continue to unfold. Although the ivy smothers native plants and kills trees by blocking sunlight and trapping moisture, English ivy can still be bought in most garden stores today.

